

The **Thembu (abaThembu)** lineage traces its seniority back to the 14th century, predating other Nguni nations like the Zulu 1, 2. The history of the chieftainship is marked by a deep integration with the **San (abaThwa)**, a connection preserved in cultural rituals and the specific lineage of the **AmaQithi**.

The Ancient Thembu Lineage (1307–1833)

Historical research identifies **Zwide** as the point where ancestor-praises (*unqulo*) for Ntu-speaking nations often end 3, 4. The lineage through the Great House is generally recorded as follows:

- **Njanya (c. 1307)**: A foundational ancestor common to the Mpondo, Thembu, and Xhosa 5-7.
- **Malandela**: The first-born of Njanya; the Thembu are considered senior to the Xhosa because they descend from this senior son 8, 9.
- **Bomoyi (c. 1517)**: A key figure whose death led to a succession crisis between his sons, **Zima** and **Ntande** 5, 9.
- **Ntande**: The rightful heir of the Great House whose uncles fought to secure his throne from his older brother, Zima 9.
- **Nxego (c. 1600)**: His grave at the Msana River marks the earliest traceable burial site in central Thembuland 10, 11.
- **Hlanga and Dlomo (c. 1650)**: Brothers who split the nation; the **AmaDlomo** became the ruling Great House, while Hlanga's descendants became the **AmaQiya** 10, 12, 13.
- **Successive Chiefs**: The line continued through **Tato** (c. 1700), **Zondwa** (c. 1725), and **Ndaba** (c. 1756) 12, 14.
- **Ngubengcuka (Vusani) (d. 1833)**: The Paramount Chief during the early 19th-century frontier conflicts who raised the heir **Mtirara** 15, 16.

The Modern Era to King Buyelekhaya (1833–Present)

- **Mtirara**: Son of Ngubengcuka, he was raised by the regent **Queen Nonesi** at Rhodana 16.
- **Ngangelizwe (Qeya)**: Son of Mtirara, he ruled during the late 19th-century colonial expansion 16.
- **Dalindyebo (c. 1920)**: His reign was a watershed moment, marking the transition into the modern administrative era 17, 18.
- **Sampu Jongilizwe Dalindyebo (1924–1928)**: Succeeded his father but died early without a Great Wife, leading to a long era of regencies 19, 20.
- **The Regents (1928–1954)**: The chieftainship was held by **Jongintaba (Daweti)** and **Dabulamanzi** until the heir was of age 21, 22.
- **Sabata Jonguhlanga Dalindyebo (1954–1986)**: A popular monarch who opposed the apartheid-era Bantustan system; he was deposed and died in exile 18, 23, 24.
- **King Buyelekhaya Dalindyebo (1992–Present)**: After the death of Sabata and a brief period under the houses of Bambilanga and Zondwa, **Buyelekhaya Zwelibanzi** was proclaimed heir in 1987 and officially appointed in 1992 25-27.

The San and the AmaQithi

The AbaThembu are historically a **creolized population** formed by the fusion of immigrant Nguni groups and indigenous San communities 28-30.

- **The "Tambookie" Matrix:** The name "Tambookie" is a colonial version of the Khoisan term **Tam'bou'ci**, used to describe the mixed San-Thembu groups living along the Tsomo and Kei rivers 28, 30, 31.
- **AmaQithi:** This clan is a **derived branch** of the Thembu Great House that preserves a direct San ritual lineage History, 424. They were known as "Royal San" who served as ritual specialists and rainmakers for the Thembu kings History, 126.
- **Ritual of Ingqithi:** The Thembu adopted the San custom of **amputating the first joint of the little finger** (*ingqithi*) as a tribal marker 32-34. This shared ritual is considered definitive proof of the "friendly amalgamation" between the two races 28/396, 388.
- **Respect for Resources:** Early Thembu chiefs gave San hunters precedence over themselves at large game kills, recognizing the San as the **original owners of the land** 32, 34, 35.
- **San Chiefs:** Leaders like **Madolo (Madoor)** and **Madakane** managed territories at the White Kei confluence, interacting with Thembu leaders like Jumba to form multi-ethnic sanctuaries like the **Bushman School** in 1842 23, 28/399, 110, 390.